



Security in Computer Networks

Way back in Section 1.6 we described some of the more prevalent and damaging classes of Internet attacks, including malware attacks, denial of service, sniffing, source masquerading, and message modification and deletion. Although we have since learned a tremendous amount about computer networks, we still haven't examined how to secure networks from those attacks. Equipped with our newly acquired expertise in computer networking and Internet protocols, we'll now study in-depth secure communication and, in particular, how computer networks can be defended from those nasty bad guys.

Let us introduce Alice and Bob, two people who want to communicate and wish to do so “securely.” This being a networking text, we should remark that Alice and Bob could be two routers that want to exchange routing tables securely, a client and server that want to establish a secure transport connection, or two e-mail applications that want to exchange secure e-mail—all case studies that we will consider later in this chapter. Alice and Bob are well-known fixtures in the security community, perhaps because their names are more fun than a generic entity named “A” that wants to communicate securely with a generic entity named “B.” Love affairs, wartime communication, and business transactions are the commonly cited human needs for secure communications; preferring the first to the latter two, we're happy to use Alice and Bob as our sender and receiver, and imagine them in this first scenario.

We said that Alice and Bob want to communicate and wish to do so “securely,” but what precisely does this mean? As we will see, security (like love) is a many-splendored thing; that is, there are many facets to security. Certainly, Alice and Bob would like for the contents of their communication to remain secret from an eavesdropper. They probably would also like to make sure that when they are communicating, they are indeed communicating with each other, and that if their communication is tampered with by an eavesdropper, that this tampering is detected. In the first part of this chapter, we’ll cover the fundamental cryptography techniques that allow for encrypting communication, authenticating the party with whom one is communicating, and ensuring message integrity.

In the second part of this chapter, we’ll examine how the fundamental cryptography principles can be used to create secure networking protocols. Once again taking a top-down approach, we’ll examine secure protocols in each of the (top four) layers, beginning with the application layer. We’ll examine how to secure e-mail, how to secure a TCP connection, how to provide blanket security at the network layer, and how to secure a wireless LAN. In the third part of this chapter we’ll consider operational security, which is about protecting organizational networks from attacks. In particular, we’ll take a careful look at how firewalls and intrusion detection systems can enhance the security of an organizational network.

8.1 What Is Network Security?

Let’s begin our study of network security by returning to our lovers, Alice and Bob, who want to communicate “securely.” What precisely does this mean? Certainly, Alice wants only Bob to be able to understand a message that she has sent, even though they *are* communicating over an insecure medium where an intruder (Trudy, the intruder) may intercept whatever is transmitted from Alice to Bob. Bob also wants to be sure that the message he receives from Alice was indeed sent by Alice, and Alice wants to make sure that the person with whom she is communicating is indeed Bob. Alice and Bob also want to make sure that the contents of their messages have not been altered in transit. They also want to be assured that they can communicate in the first place (i.e., that no one denies them access to the resources needed to communicate). Given these considerations, we can identify the following desirable properties of **secure communication**.

- *Confidentiality*. Only the sender and intended receiver should be able to understand the contents of the transmitted message. Because eavesdroppers may intercept the message, this necessarily requires that the message be somehow **encrypted** so that an intercepted message cannot be understood by an interceptor. This aspect of confidentiality is probably the most commonly perceived